

Action Plan for the Reform of Research Assessment of the University of Zaragoza

1. Objectives of the University of Zaragoza in relation to the principles of COARA

Although the process of reforming research assessment will need to be informed, discussed and agreed upon, the objectives of the Action Plan for its further development need to be defined. In our case, we propose as main objectives:

- That the University of Zaragoza participates in the movement for the reform of the assessment of research and informs the University Community of its development at national and European level.
- Involve the university community in the process and ensure broad participation in it.
- Promote a broader recognition of research careers, evaluating them according to their achievements and impact, with special emphasis on the transfer of knowledge to the Society and respect for early research careers.
- Train researchers in the central aspects of the reform.
- Take into consideration all areas of knowledge, since there are specific particularities to address in each case.
- Provide legal certainty in procedures, establishing clear, transparent and equitable rules that avoid arbitrariness and provide certainty for researchers at all stages of their career and for members of evaluation and/or selection committees.
- Participate in national and European structures, collaborating in working groups and especially in the national chapter.
- Share all information with the University Community in an open and proactive way.

2. Scope of the action plan

The reform of research assessment is therefore a relevant issue for the future of research activity. At the same time, it represents a sensitive action, due to the importance of this evaluation, not only in the field of academic recognition, but because it involves the professional career in all its phases.

Additionally, most of the researchers of the University of Zaragoza participate in evaluation processes that are neither designed nor carried out by it: the award of research initiation contracts, six-year research incentives (*sexenios*), and calls for regional, national or European projects. As a result, much of the research staff assessment processes are outside the scope of this action plan.

That is why the action plan, in those aspects related to the direct implementation of the ARRA commitments, should be limited to two specific areas:

- Calls within the University of Zaragoza's own research plan that require an assessment of the applications of researchers, groups, centers or research institutes.

In this case, the ARRA commitments can be applied without restrictions, and it must be ensured that the processes are open, transparent, based on evidence and broad criteria with a reasonable and responsible use of the metrics.

- Calls for researcher or teaching positions in which the evaluation of the research activity is relevant. In these cases, the University of Zaragoza has the possibility to suggest the application of the ARRA commitments in the evaluation criteria of the different commissions. It can play an active role in informing and advising, with the aim of harmonising and, if requested, exemplifying how to apply those principles. In this way, it is sought that the evaluation commissions know them and, in due course, can incorporate them into their assessment processes.

In addition to these aspects, and given that at a European and national level we are already finding research curriculum evaluations in which ARRA commitments are being applied, it is fundamental, and independent of our progress in applying these principles, to train our researchers. This training should be aimed, fundamentally, at the youngest, with topics such as narrative curricula, the design of research methodologies based on Open Science or the enhancement of the impact on research. Knowing these subjects will be essential in the coming years since they are already being implemented in European and national evaluation organizations such as ANECA .

The action plan of the University of Zaragoza will, in any case, be subject to the interests of the institution itself and its researchers, and especially those with early *research careers*.

3. Action Plan

ARRA commitments	Lines of action	Actions	Timeline	Responsible	Assessment method
5. Commit resources to reform research assessment as needed to achieve committed organizational changes.	Actions to ensure the preparation, implementation, development and monitoring of the UNIZAR CoARA Action Plan	Creation of the UNIZAR CoARA Action Plan Working Group.	1Q2025	Rector - VR Science Policy	Appointment of the Group
		Implementation, development and follow-up of the action plan	2025-2027	CoARA Working Group	Six-monthly and annual meetings. Validation of annual reports
		Establishment of an annual budget for the implementation of the actions set out in the UNIZAR 2025-2027 CoARA Action Plan	2025-2027	VR Science Policy	Annual monitoring report
6. Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes	Design and update the criteria, documents, guidelines for applicants and assessments of UNIZAR in accordance with the principles of CoARA	Analysis of the methodologies and evaluation criteria of other public bodies and institutions.	3Q2025	CoARA Working Group	Roadmap of national and international assessment systems. Analysis report
		Conducting focus groups with researchers to analyze methodologies and criteria in different areas of interest	4Q2025	CoARA Working Group	Open reports of meetings
		Mapping of the different calls, tools and mechanisms of UNIZAR currently implemented.	2Q2025	UNIZAR Research Vice-Management	Open report
		Review and update of the different calls of UNIZAR according to the perspective of CoARA.	2026-2027	VR Science Policy	Semi-annual and annual meetings and open report.
7. Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance and training on evaluation criteria and processes, as well as their use	Internal strategy to disseminate the principles of CoARA	Establishment of actions with teaching and research staff to disseminate the principles of CoARA and present the internal application	2025-2027	CoARA Working Group	Meetings, seminars, webinars.
		Preparation of guidelines for the submission of	2026-2027	VR Science Policy	Guides for each of the adapted internal calls

		internal calls adapted to CoARA			
	Strategy for internal communication of the Action Plan	Development of a communication plan designated for the action plan	2Q2025	VR Science Policy	Communication plan
		Implementation of the external communication actions set out in the communication plan	2025-2027	VR Science Policy	External communication actions
	Training on CoARA principles	Training actions related to all research assessment situations: research periods and accreditations, projects, etc.	2025-2027	CoARA Working Group	Courses on "CV Narrative", Citizen Science, Responsible Research & Innovation (RRI)"
		Harmonization actions and training on the principles of CoARA in those structures responsible for the selection of personnel where the research profile is important	2025-2027	VR Science Policy	Reports on meetings with departments, faculties, IUIs, etc.
8. Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and outside the Coalition	Communication, exchange of practices and feedback with other CoARA regional, national and international institutions	Participation in the Spanish chapter of CoARA	2025-2027	Representatives of the CoARA Working Group	Annual report
		Participation in other CoARA working groups and committees or other regional, national or international research assessment groups	2025-2027	Representatives of the CoARA Working Group	Number of exchanges and practices.
9. Communicate progress on adherence to principles and implementation of commitments		CoARA website at UNIZAR	2025-2027	CoARA Working Group	Updating the website
		Publication of the progress of the UNIZAR CoARA action plan and annual reporting at national and international events.	2025-2027		Participation in meetings
10. Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and state-of-the-art research, and make data available in open for evidence collection and research.	Analyze and monitor practices likely to be improved	Identification, testing and evaluation of possible changes.	2025-2027		Publication of results

		Assess whether to carry out, in the light of progress, research evaluation reform pilots beyond changes in the own research programme.	2Q2026	CoARA Working Group	Meeting reports
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5. Governance and deployment

The action plan will be led by the Vice-Rectorate of Scientific Policy and approved by the different levels of the University of Zaragoza. A CoARA Working Group will be created to develop, deploy and monitor the plan. This Working Group will be composed of those interested within the HRS4R Strategy Working Group, as well as a limited number of people who will be invited in a way that ensures that all degrees of research staff (R1 to R4) as well as administrative, technical and management personnel of the research are represented.

The CoARA Action Plan should be approved and be operational by Q2 2025.

Approved by the Management Board of the University of Zaragoza in April 2025